

02. Nationalism in India

Session 01 –

01. Explain the impact of the First World War on Indian economy?

OR

Explain what problems the First World War created in India.

- The war created a new economic and political situation.
- It led to a huge increase in defence expenditure which was financed by war loans and increasing taxes: customs duties were raised and income tax introduced.
- Through the war years prices increased – doubling between 1913 and 1918 – leading to extreme hardship for the common people.
- Villages were called upon to supply soldiers, and the forced recruitment in rural areas caused widespread anger.
- Then in 1918-19 and 1920-21, crops failed in many parts of India, resulting in acute shortages of food. This was accompanied by an influenza epidemic. According to the census of 1921, 12 to 13 million people perished as a result of famines and the epidemic.

02. What do you mean by satyagraha?

It means firm adhere to truth.

03. Against whom Gandhi ji started movement in South Africa?

Mahatma Gandhi returned to India in January 1915. He had come from South Africa where he had successfully fought the racist regime with a novel method of mass agitation, which he called satyagraha.

04. Explain the idea of satyagraha.

The idea of satyagraha emphasised the power of truth and the need to search for truth. It suggested that if the cause was true, if the struggle was against injustice, then physical force was not necessary to fight the oppressor. Without seeking vengeance or being aggressive, a satyagrahi could win the battle through nonviolence. This could be done by appealing to the conscience of the oppressor. People – including the oppressors – had to be persuaded to see the truth, instead of being forced to accept truth through the use of violence. By this struggle, truth was bound to ultimately triumph. Mahatma Gandhi believed that this dharma of non-violence could unite all Indians.

05. Give a brief description of local satyagraha organized by Gandhi ji.

- After arriving in India, Mahatma Gandhi successfully organised satyagraha movements in various places. In 1917 he travelled to Champaran in Bihar to inspire the peasants to struggle against the oppressive plantation system.
- Then in 1917, he organised a satyagraha to support the peasants of the Kheda district of Gujarat. Affected by crop failure and a plague epidemic, the peasants of Kheda could not pay the revenue, and were demanding that revenue collection be relaxed.
- In 1918, Mahatma Gandhi went to Ahmedabad to organise a satyagraha movement amongst cotton mill workers.

06. What was the Rowlatt Act of 1919?

The Rowlatt Act of 1919 was framed by Sir Sidney Rowlatt. The Rowlatt Act had been hurriedly passed through the Imperial Legislative Council despite the united opposition of the Indian members. It gave the government enormous powers to repress political activities, and allowed detention of political prisoners without trial for two years.

07. Give a brief description of Rowlatt-Satyagraha movement?

02. Nationalism in India

OR

What actions the British government took to suppress the Rowlatt-Satyagraha movement?

- The Rowlatt Act of 1919 was framed by Sir Sidney Rowlatt. The Rowlatt Act had been hurriedly passed through the Imperial Legislative Council despite the united opposition of the Indian members. It gave the government enormous powers to repress political activities, and allowed detention of political prisoners without trial for two years.
- Mahatma Gandhi wanted non-violent civil disobedience against such unjust laws, which would start with a hartal on 6 April.
- Rallies were organised in various cities, workers went on strike in railway workshops, and shops closed down. Alarmed by the popular upsurge.
- The British administration decided to clamp down on nationalists.
- Local leaders like Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew and Dr. Satyapal were picked up from Amritsar, and Mahatma Gandhi was barred from entering Delhi.
- On 10 April, the police in Amritsar fired upon a peaceful procession, provoking widespread attacks on banks, post offices and railway stations. Martial law was imposed and General Dyer took command.

08. Explain briefly the Jallianwalla Bagh incident and its effect on Punjab.

OR

Explain how Indians react against the Jallianwalla Bagh incident and how government suppressed the Satyagrahis.

- The Rowlatt Act of 1919 was framed by Sir Sidney Rowlatt. Against this Rowlatt Act, Gandhi ji started the Rowlatt-Satyagraha movement on 6 April 1919. Indians participated in large number in this movement and the British government used firm measures to suppress the movement.
- On 13 April the infamous Jallianwalla Bagh incident took place. On that day a large crowd gathered in the enclosed ground of Jallianwalla Bagh.
- Some came to protest against the government's new repressive measures. Others had come to attend the annual Baisakhi fair.
- Being from outside the city, many villagers were unaware of the martial law that had been imposed.
- Dyer entered the area, blocked the exit points, and opened fire on the crowd, killing hundreds.
- As the news of Jallianwalla Bagh spread, crowds took to the streets in many north Indian towns. There were strikes, clashes with the police and attacks on government buildings.
- The government responded with brutal repression, seeking to humiliate and terrorise people: satyagrahis were forced to rub their noses on the ground, crawl on the streets, and do salaam (salute) to all sahibs; people were flogged and villages (around Gujranwala in Punjab, now in Pakistan) were bombed. Seeing violence spread, Mahatma Gandhi called off the movement.

09. What were causes of launching the Khilafat movement in 1909?

- After the failure of Rowlatt-Satyagraha movement, Mahatma Gandhi felt the need to launch a more broad-based movement in India. But he was certain that no such movement could

02. Nationalism in India

be organised without bringing the Hindus and Muslims closer together. One way of doing this, he felt, was to take up the Khilafat issue.

- The First World War had ended with the defeat of Ottoman Turkey. And there were rumours that a harsh peace treaty was going to be imposed on the Ottoman emperor – the spiritual head of the Islamic world (the Khalifa).
- To defend the Khalifa's temporal powers, a Khilafat Committee was formed in Bombay in March 1919. A young generation of Muslim leaders like the brothers Muhammad Ali and Shaukat Ali, began discussing with Mahatma Gandhi about the possibility of a united mass action on the issue.
- Gandhiji saw this as an opportunity to bring Muslims under the umbrella of a unified national movement.
- At the Calcutta session of the Congress in September 1920, he convinced other leaders of the need to start a non-cooperation movement in support of Khilafat as well as for swaraj.

10. Name the book written by Mahatma Gandhi in 1909.

The book written by Mahatma Gandhi in 1909 was the Hind Swaraj.

11. Why did Gandhiji thought of Non-Cooperation only?

- In his famous book Hind Swaraj (1909) Mahatma Gandhi declared that British rule was established in India with the cooperation of Indians, and had survived only because of this cooperation.
- If Indians refused to cooperate, British rule in India would collapse within a year, and swaraj would come.

12. How could Non-Cooperation become a movement?

OR

Unfold the stages of NCM.

OR

What were the proposed stages of NCM?

OR

'British rule in India... Indians had not cooperated.' Explain the statement.

OR

How did the Indians participate in the NCM?

- In his famous book Hind Swaraj (1909) Mahatma Gandhi declared that British rule was established in India with the cooperation of Indians, and had survived only because of this cooperation. If Indians refused to cooperate, British rule in India would collapse within a year, and swaraj would come.
- Gandhiji proposed that the movement should unfold in stages.
- It should begin with the surrender of titles that the government awarded, and a boycott of civil services, army, police, courts and legislative councils, schools, and foreign goods.
- Then, in case the government used repression, a full civil disobedience campaign would be launched. In this way the Indians participated in the Non-Cooperation Movement.

13. Why were many Congress leaders reluctant to join Gandhiji in NCM?

- Many within the Congress were, however, concerned about the proposals. They were reluctant to boycott the council elections scheduled for November 1920, and they feared that the movement might lead to popular violence.
- In the months between September and December there was an intense tussle within the Congress.

02. Nationalism in India

- For a while there seemed no meeting point between the supporters and the opponents of the movement.
- Finally, at the Congress session at Nagpur in December 1920, a compromise was worked out and the Non-Cooperation programme was adopted.

Session 02 –

01. When did the NCM begin?

The Non-Cooperation-Khilafat Movement began in January 1921.

02. How did the middle-class participate in the NCM?

OR

Discuss the ways of joining NCM in the town and cities?

OR

Why in Madras council elections were not boycotted?

- The movement started with middle-class participation in the cities.
- Thousands of students left government-controlled schools and colleges, headmasters and teachers resigned, and lawyers gave up their legal practices. The council elections were boycotted in most provinces.
- In Madras, the Justice Party, the party of the non-Brahmans, felt that entering the council was one way of gaining some power – something that usually only Brahmins had access to.

03. Explain the effects of NCM on economic front.

OR

How did the NCM boosted the production of Indian textile mills and handlooms?

- The effects of non-cooperation on the economic front were more dramatic.
- Foreign goods were boycotted, liquor shops picketed, and foreign cloth burnt in huge bonfires.
- The import of foreign cloth halved between 1921 and 1922, its value dropping from Rs 102 crore to Rs 57 crore.
- In many places merchants and traders refused to trade in foreign goods or finance foreign trade.
- As the boycott movement spread, and people began discarding imported clothes and wearing only Indian ones, production of Indian textile mills and handlooms went up.

04. Why people started buying mill clothes instead of khadi?

OR

Why boycott of British institutions posed a problem?

OR

Causes of slowing down of NCM in the cities?

- The Non-Cooperation movement in the cities gradually slowed down for a variety of reasons.
- Khadi cloth was often more expensive than mass-produced mill cloth and poor people could not afford to buy it.
- Similarly the boycott of British institutions posed a problem. For the movement to be successful, alternative Indian institutions had to be set up so that they could be used in place of the British ones.

02. Nationalism in India

- These were slow to come up. So students and teachers began trickling back to government schools and lawyers joined back work in government courts.

05. Trace the rise peasant agitation under the leadership of Baba Ramchandra and Nehru in Awadh?

OR

Explain how the NCM spread in the country-side.

OR

Describe the movement of tribal peasants in Andhra Pradesh.

I. Participation of peasants in NCM –

- In Awadh, peasants were led by Baba Ramchandra – a sanyasi who had earlier been to Fiji as an indentured labourer. The movement here was against talukdars and landlords who demanded from peasants exorbitantly high rents and a variety of other cesses.
- Peasants had to do begar and work at landlords' farms without any payment. As tenants they had no security of tenure, being regularly evicted so that they could acquire no right over the leased land.
- The peasant movement demanded reduction of revenue, abolition of begar, and social boycott of oppressive landlords.
- In many places nai – dhobi bandhs were organised by panchayats to deprive landlords of the services of even barbers and washermen. In June 1920, Jawaharlal Nehru began going around the villages in Awadh, talking to the villagers, and trying to understand their grievances.
- By October, the Oudh Kisan Sabha was set up headed by Jawaharlal Nehru, Baba Ramchandra and a few others. The effort of the Congress was to integrate the Awadh peasant struggle into the wider struggle.
- The 1921 peasant movement evolved into violent actions, such as looting bazaars and attacking merchants, which displeased Congress leadership. Local leaders misled peasants by claiming Mahatma Gandhi had sanctioned tax refusal and land redistribution. Consequently, Gandhi's name was frequently invoked to justify these radical actions and aspirations.

II. Participation of tribals and Adivasis in NCM –

- Tribal peasants interpreted the message of Mahatma Gandhi and the idea of swaraj in yet another way. In the Gudum Hills of Andhra Pradesh, for instance, a militant guerrilla movement spread in the early 1920s.
- In other forest regions, the colonial government had closed large forest areas, preventing people from entering the forests to graze their cattle, or to collect fuelwood and fruits.
- This enraged the hill people. Not only were their livelihoods affected but they felt that their traditional rights were being denied. When the government began forcing them to contribute begar for road building, the hill people revolted.
- The person who came to lead them was an interesting figure. Alluri Sitaram Raju claimed that he had a variety of special powers: he could make correct astrological predictions and heal people, and he could survive even bullet shots.
- Captivated by Raju, the rebels proclaimed that he was an incarnation of God. Raju talked of the greatness of Mahatma Gandhi, said he was inspired by the Non-Cooperation Movement, and persuaded people to wear khadi and give up drinking. But at the same time he asserted that India could be liberated only by the use of force, not non-violence.

- Aayan

02. Nationalism in India

- The Gudum rebels attacked police stations, attempted to kill British officials and carried on guerrilla warfare for achieving swaraj. Raju was captured and executed in 1924, and over time became a folk hero.

06. Explain the role of plantation workers of Assam in NCM.

OR

What was the Inland Emigration Act?

- For plantation workers in Assam, freedom meant the right to move freely in and out of the confined space in which they were enclosed, and it meant retaining a link with the village from which they had come.
- Under the Inland Emigration Act of 1859, plantation workers were not permitted to leave the tea gardens without permission, and in fact they were rarely given such permission.
- When they heard of the Non-Cooperation Movement, thousands of workers defied the authorities, left the plantations and headed home.
- They believed that Gandhi Raj was coming and everyone would be given land in their own villages.
- They, however, never reached their destination. Stranded on the way by a railway and steamer strike, they were caught by the police and brutally beaten up.

07. What was the Chauri Chaura incident?

OR

Why Gandhiji called off the NCM?

- Gorakhpur is a small district in Uttar Pradesh.
- A peaceful demonstration in the bazaar was carried out by a mob of peasants at Chauri Chaura in Gorakhpur on 4th February 1922.
- The British police heard about the demonstration and decided to repress with power. The police lathi charged upon the peaceful demonstrators.
- The peaceful demonstrators turned violent and locked the policemen inside the police station and put the police station on fire. 22 policemen were burnt alive.
- After hearing the news of the incident and violence, Gandhiji called off the NCM.

Session 03 –

01. Why did Gandhiji decide to withdraw or call off the NCM?

In February 1922, Mahatma Gandhi decided to withdraw the Non-Cooperation Movement. He felt the movement was turning violent in many places and satyagrahis needed to be properly trained before they would be ready for mass struggles.

02. Why did the Congress leaders want to participate in elections to the provincial councils?

Within the Congress, some leaders were by now tired of mass struggles and wanted to participate in elections to the provincial councils that had been set up by the Government of India Act of 1919. They felt that it was important to oppose British policies within the councils, argue for reform and also demonstrate that these councils were not truly democratic.

03. Who formed the Swaraj Party and why?

C. R. Das and Motilal Nehru formed the Swaraj Party within the Congress to argue for a return to council politics. But younger leaders like Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose pressed for more radical mass agitation and for full independence.

04. Why was the Simon Commission sent to India?

02. Nationalism in India

- The new Tory government in Britain constituted a Statutory Commission under Sir John Simon.
 - The commission was to look into the functioning of the constitutional system in India and suggest changes.
 - The problem was that the commission did not have a single Indian member. They were all British.
 - When the Simon Commission arrived in India in 1928, it was greeted with the slogan 'Go back Simon'.
 - All parties, including the Congress and the Muslim League, participated in the demonstrations.
- 05. Why was the offer of dominion status by Lord Irwin rejected by the Congress?**
- In an effort to win the support of the Congress regarding Simon Commission, the viceroy, Lord Irwin, announced in October 1929, a vague offer of 'dominion status' for India in an unspecified future, and a Round Table Conference to discuss a future constitution.
 - The radicals within the Congress, led by Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose, became more assertive.
 - The liberals and moderates, who were proposing a constitutional system within the framework of British dominion, gradually lost their influence.
- 06. When, where and by whom the demand of 'Purna Swaraj' was formalised?**

OR

What resolution was passed in Congress Session of Lahore in December 1929?

In December 1929, under the presidency of Jawaharlal Nehru, the Lahore Congress formalised the demand of 'Purna Swaraj' or full independence for India. It was declared that 26 January 1930, would be celebrated as the Independence Day when people were to take a pledge to struggle for complete independence. But the celebrations attracted very little attention. So Mahatma Gandhi had to find a way to relate this abstract idea of freedom to more concrete issues of everyday life.

- 07. Why salt was considered a more effective weapon for protest against Britishers?**

OR

Why demand for abolition of salt tax was made?

OR

Give a brief description of Dandi March or Salt-Satyagraha.

- Mahatma Gandhi found in salt a powerful symbol that could unite the nation. On 31 January 1930, he sent a letter to Viceroy Irwin stating eleven demands.
- Some of these were of general interest; others were specific demands of different classes, from industrialists to peasants. The idea was to make the demands wide-ranging, so that all classes within Indian society could identify with them and everyone could be brought together in a united campaign.
- The most stirring of all was the demand to abolish the salt tax. Salt was something consumed by the rich and the poor alike, and it was one of the most essential items of food.
- The tax on salt and the government monopoly over its production, Mahatma Gandhi declared, revealed the most oppressive face of British rule.
- Mahatma Gandhi's letter was, in a way, an ultimatum. If the demands were not fulfilled by 11 March, the letter stated, the Congress would launch a civil disobedience campaign.

02. Nationalism in India

- Irwin was unwilling to negotiate. So Mahatma Gandhi started his famous salt march accompanied by 78 of his trusted volunteers.
- The march was over 240 miles, from Gandhiji's ashram in Sabarmati to the Gujarati coastal town of Dandi. The volunteers walked for 24 days, about 10 miles a day. Thousands came to hear Mahatma Gandhi wherever he stopped, and he told them what he meant by swaraj and urged them to peacefully defy the British. On 6 April he reached Dandi, and ceremonially violated the law, manufacturing salt by boiling sea water.

08. Explain how the Indians participate in the Civil Disobedience Movement (CDM).

Thousands in different parts of the country broke the salt law, manufactured salt and demonstrated in front of government salt factories. As the movement spread, foreign cloth was boycotted, and liquor shops were picketed. Peasants refused to pay revenue and chaukidari taxes, village officials resigned, and in many places forest people violated forest laws – going into Reserved Forests to collect wood and graze cattle.

09. What actions did the British government take after the Dandi March?

OR

Why Gandhiji called off the CDM?

- Worried by the developments, the colonial government began arresting the Congress leaders one by one. This led to violent clashes in many places.
- When Abdul Ghaffar Khan, a devout disciple of Mahatma Gandhi, was arrested in April 1930, angry crowds demonstrated in the streets of Peshawar, facing armoured cars and police firing. Many were killed.
- A month later, when Mahatma Gandhi himself was arrested, industrial workers in Sholapur attacked police posts, municipal buildings, lawcourts and railway stations – all structures that symbolised British rule.
- A frightened government responded with a policy of brutal repression. Peaceful satyagrahis were attacked, women and children were beaten, and about 100,000 people were arrested.

10. What was Gandhi-Irwin Pact?

Due to violence, Mahatma Gandhi once again decided to call off the movement and entered into a pact with Irwin on 5 March 1931. By this Gandhi-Irwin Pact, Gandhiji consented to participate in a Round Table Conference (the Congress had boycotted the first Round Table Conference) in London and the government agreed to release the political prisoners.

11. Explain why Gandhiji re-launched the Civil Disobedience Movement (CDM).

- In December 1931, Gandhiji went to London for the conference, but the negotiations broke down and he returned disappointed.
- Back in India, he discovered that the government had begun a new cycle of repression. Ghaffar Khan and Jawaharlal Nehru were both in jail, the Congress had been declared illegal, and a series of measures had been imposed to prevent meetings, demonstrations and boycotts.
- With great apprehension, Mahatma Gandhi relaunched the Civil Disobedience Movement. For over a year, the movement continued, but by 1934 it lost its momentum.'

12. Why did the rich peasant communities take part in the CDM? Why they refused to participate when the CDM was re-launched?

02. Nationalism in India

- In the countryside, rich peasant communities – like the Patidars of Gujarat and the Jats of Uttar Pradesh – were active in the movement. Being producers of commercial crops, they were very hard hit by the trade depression and falling prices.
- As their cash income disappeared, they found it impossible to pay the government's revenue demand.
- And the refusal of the government to reduce the revenue demand led to widespread resentment. These rich peasants became enthusiastic supporters of the Civil Disobedience Movement, organising their communities, and at times forcing reluctant members, to participate in the boycott programmes.
- For them the fight for swaraj was a struggle against high revenues. But they were deeply disappointed when the movement was called off in 1931 without the revenue rates being revised. So when the movement was restarted in 1932, many of them refused to participate.

13. Why the poor peasantry joined the CDM?

- The poorer peasantry were not just interested in the lowering of the revenue demand.
- Many of them were small tenants cultivating land they had rented from landlords.
- As the Depression continued and cash incomes dwindled, the small tenants found it difficult to pay their rent.
- They wanted the unpaid rent to the landlord to be remitted.
- Apprehensive of raising issues that might upset the rich peasants and landlords, the Congress was unwilling to support 'no rent' campaigns in most places. So the relationship between the poor peasants and the Congress remained uncertain.

14. How did the business class relate to the CDM? Why they withdrew from second CDM?

OR

Why they withdrew support from CDM when it was re-launched?

- During the First World War, Indian merchants and industrialists had made huge profits and become powerful. Keen on expanding their business, they now reacted against colonial policies that restricted business activities.
- They wanted protection against imports of foreign goods, and a rupee-sterling foreign exchange ratio that would discourage imports.
- To organise business interests, they formed the Indian Industrial and Commercial Congress in 1920 and the Federation of the Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industries (FICCI) in 1927. Led by prominent industrialists like Purshottamdas Thakurdas and G. D. Birla, the industrialists attacked colonial control over the Indian economy, and supported the Civil Disobedience Movement when it was first launched.
- They gave financial assistance and refused to buy or sell imported goods.
- Most businessmen came to see swaraj as a time when colonial restrictions on business would no longer exist and trade and industry would flourish without constraints.
- But after the failure of the Round Table Conference, business groups were no longer uniformly enthusiastic. They were apprehensive of the spread of militant activities, and worried about prolonged disruption of business, as well as of the growing influence of socialism amongst the younger members of the Congress.

15. How did the industrial working class participate in the CDM?

- The industrial working classes did not participate in the Civil Disobedience Movement in large numbers, except in the Nagpur region.

02. Nationalism in India

- As the industrialists came closer to the Congress, workers stayed aloof. But in spite of that, some workers did participate in the Civil Disobedience Movement, selectively adopting some of the ideas of the Gandhian programme, like boycott of foreign goods, as part of their own movements against low wages and poor working conditions.
- There were strikes by railway workers in 1930 and dockworkers in 1932.
- In 1930 thousands of workers in Chotanagpur tin mines wore Gandhi caps and participated in protest rallies and boycott campaigns.
- But the Congress was reluctant to include workers' demands as part of its programme of struggle. It felt that this would alienate industrialists and divide the anti-imperial forces.

16. Explain the role of women in the CDM?

- During Gandhiji's salt march, thousands of women came out of their homes to listen to him.
- They participated in protest marches, manufactured salt, and picketed foreign cloth and liquor shops. Many went to jail. In urban areas these women were from high-caste families; in rural areas they came from rich peasant households. Moved by Gandhiji's call, they began to see service to the nation as a sacred duty of women.

17. What were Gandhiji's view on women's participation in the National movement? Why was Congress reluctant to allow women to hold any position within the organization?

Gandhiji was convinced that it was the duty of women to look after home and hearth, be good mothers and good wives. And for a long time, the Congress was reluctant to allow women to hold any position of authority within the organisation. It was keen only on their symbolic presence.

18. Which social groups did not participate in the CDM?

OR

Why Dalits did not join the CDM? Why did some Muslim political organization did not join the CDM?

[Note - If the questions come separate, write only their respective answers]

I. Dalit / Untouchables –

- Since 1930s, the untouchables had begun to call themselves Dalit or oppressed.
- The Congress had ignored the Dalits, for fear of offending the Sanatanis, the conservative high-caste Hindus.
- But Mahatma Gandhi declared that swaraj would not come for a hundred years if untouchability was not eliminated.
- He called the 'untouchables' harijan, or the children of God, organised satyagraha to secure them entry into temples, and access to public wells, tanks, roads and schools. He himself cleaned toilets to dignify the work of the Bhangi (the sweepers), and persuaded upper castes to change their heart and give up 'the sin of untouchability'.

II. Muslim Political Organizations –

- Some of the Muslim political organisations in India were also lukewarm in their response to the Civil Disobedience Movement.
- After the decline of the Non-Cooperation-Khilafat Movement, a large section of Muslims felt alienated from the Congress.
- From the mid-1920s the Congress came to be more visibly associated with openly Hindu religious nationalist groups like the Hindu Mahasabha.

02. Nationalism in India

- As relations between Hindus and Muslims worsened, each community organised religious processions with militant fervour, provoking Hindu-Muslim communal clashes and riots in various cities. Every riot deepened the distance between the two communities.

19. What measures were taken by Dalit leaders to improve their political condition or status?

- Many Dalit leaders were keen on a different political solution to the problems of the community.
- They began organising themselves, demanding reserved seats in educational institutions, and a separate electorate that would choose Dalit members for legislative councils.
- Political empowerment, they believed, would resolve the problems of their social disabilities.
- Dalit participation in the Civil Disobedience Movement was therefore limited, particularly in the Maharashtra and Nagpur region where their organisation was quite strong.

20. What was Dr. BR Ambedkar's proposal for Dalits? What was the Poona Pact? Why was Gandhiji against separate electorates for the Dalits?

- Dr B.R. Ambedkar, who organised the Dalits into the Depressed Classes Association in 1930, clashed with Mahatma Gandhi at the second Round Table Conference by demanding separate electorates for Dalits.
- When the British government conceded Ambedkar's demand, Gandhiji began a fast unto death.
- He believed that separate electorates for Dalits would slow down the process of their integration into society.
- Ambedkar ultimately accepted Gandhiji's position and the result was the Poona Pact of September 1932.
- It gave the Depressed Classes (later to be known as the Schedule Castes) reserved seats in provincial and central legislative councils, but they were to be voted in by the general electorate. The Dalit movement, however, continued to be apprehensive of the Congress-led national movement.

21. What was Muhammad Ali Jinnah's proposal for Muslims?

Muhammad Ali Jinnah, one of the leaders of the Muslim League, was willing to give up the demand for separate electorates, if Muslims were assured reserved seats in the Central Assembly and representation in proportion to population in the Muslim-dominated provinces (Bengal and Punjab).

22. Why there was an atmosphere of suspicion and distrust between the Congress and the League or between the Hindus and Muslims?

When the Civil Disobedience Movement started there was thus an atmosphere of suspicion and distrust between communities. Alienated from the Congress, large sections of Muslims could not respond to the call for a united struggle. Many Muslim leaders and intellectuals expressed their concern about the status of Muslims as a minority within India. They feared that the culture and identity of minorities would be submerged under the domination of a Hindu majority.

- THIS IS NOT THE END -